An army officer once described him as a “character from a Greek tragedy”. Netanyahu, after all, is both a gifted politician and an educated man—a keen student of world history and contemporary geopolitics. As a man of the right, the son of a prominent Revisionist historian and a former army commando, he had the stature to be a transformative politician in the mold of Menachem Begin. “But he’s full of hubris,” the officer said. His lust for power led him to pursue short-term tactics instead of grand strategy, and the fabric of Israeli society unraveled while he did. Of all the many ways I’ve heard Netanyahu described, it seemed the most apt.

Tofu man

Of course, he will not be in office forever. Yet if he is forced aside, the list of possible replacements is quite thin. Herzog is finished. His inglorious stint as opposition leader has left him struggling to keep control of his own Labor party, now hopelessly adrift. Tzipi Livni is disliked by a large swathe of the Israeli public; so is Barak. Bennett and his party are too narrowly ideological. While the retired generals could challenge Netanyahu on his strongest issues, they would need to find a political home. There is some talk of Netanyahu’s eldest son Yair launching a political career, a dynastic succession that would further accelerate Israel’s integration into the Middle East, but it seems unlikely. Yair lacks a power base of his own, and his support will likely evaporate when his father’s career ends. Israelis desperately want a new leader. But the state of Israeli politics and society makes it difficult to envision one.

The one plausible alternative, at least according to the polls, is Yair Lapid, the chairman of Yesh Atid. He comes from a political family: his Yugoslav-born father Tommy spent nearly a decade in the Knesset as a lawmaker with Shinui (“Change”), a now-defunct secular and libertarian party. Like his dad, Yair started his career as a journalist, with a lengthy stint as a talk show host on Channel 2. He left media for politics ahead of the 2013 election and founded Yesh Atid, a centrist party focused largely on social and economic issues. It was the dark horse of the election, winning 19 seats, enough to make it the second-largest party. In the wake of the 2011 social protests, the party’s message resonated with voters. So did his call for the ultra-Orthodox to “share the burden,” an ideology he inherited from his father, who was a fierce opponent of the *haredi* parties. (Tommy